



# MIDDLE SEPIK

RIVER PEOPLE OF PAPUA NEW GUINEA

THE SEPIK IS A LONG RIVER THAT RUNS through mainland Papua New Guinea, from the highlands to the coast, and all along it live different clans. The people of the Middle Sepik live along the river, inland from the



## LIVING ON STILTS

The houses along the Sepik river are mainly built on stilts. This is so that during the rainy season, when the water level rises, the houses are in no danger of flooding. The stilts also prevent too many mosquitoes and rats from infesting the houses.



## COLLECTING FOOD

Men, women, and children all share the fishing jobs in the Middle Sepik area. They use long dugout canoes to catch large eels and crocodiles, and set traps in the water or use spears to catch fish. They make flour from sago palms in the swamps and keep chickens and pigs in the villages.

## The river

The Sepik River is roughly 700 miles (1,100 km) from source to mouth and is navigable for almost its entire length. It is vital to the local people who live on its banks—they use it for transportation, water, and food. Many of the legends in the area are connected to the river and it is regarded as a spirit itself.

Two dugout canoes negotiate one of the many narrow waterways on the river.

## THE CROCODILE

The Sepik people honor the crocodile and there are many myths and legends surrounding it. The people have lots of spirits or gods and the crocodile is one such spirit of the river. When making canoes, the Sepik people often carve the head of a crocodile on the prow.

